

VERSTAPPEN CHARGED FROM 17TH PLACE TO WIN THE RAIN-HIT AND INCIDENT-LADEN BRAZILIAN GRAND PRIX

More significant still was that he won with a lead of over 19 seconds over the car behind — the unheralded Alpine of Esteban Ocon. **The Dutchman couldn't have chosen a better time to emerge from a 10-race winless slump, though his fighting spirit was never in doubt.** Despite some risky moves and finding himself in the hot seat over his dipping form, the three-time World Champion pulled off one of the greatest races of his career, which now almost certainly guarantees him a fourth successive crown.

However, the scene before the Brazil race painted a slightly different picture. With a sprint race win and pole position, Norris had a 44-point deficit against Verstappen, who qualified only 12th and faced an additional five-place penalty, dropping him

down to 17th. All he needed to do was protect his lead, but little did he know that his miserable pole-to-win conversion (two wins from eight poles) would come back to haunt him.

The 24-year-old had the pace and team support throughout the weekend — his teammate Oscar Piastri was instructed to let Norris pass not once, but twice, including for the sprint race victory. Yet it was Brazil's weather that had the final say, making an event-packed, early-start Sunday one to forget for the discouraged Norris.

It was, however, memorable for defending champion Verstappen and for a certain Lewis Hamilton, who had the 'greatest honour of his career' driving the late Ayrton

Senna's McLaren MP4/5B from his title-winning 1990 campaign.

In the chaos that unfolded, one team arguably stood out from the rest — Alpine. Both its drivers, Ocon and third-placed Pierre Gasly, would never have imagined finishing on the podium, let alone together. With a mighty points haul, the French side took a huge stride in the Constructors' Championship, climbing from ninth (14 points) to sixth (49), keeping alive the midfield battle among the teams.

At the top of the table, however, a three-way battle is ongoing, with McLaren (593) leading but Ferrari (557) and Red Bull (544) within striking distance.

While both UK-based outfits mainly benefited in Brazil, Ferrari managed to stay in the fight thanks to its double podium finish in Mexico, where Carlos Sainz stole the show, though the drama between Norris and Verstappen headlined the race.

The Spaniard had made his

Ode to a legend: Lewis Hamilton drove the late Ayrton Senna's McLaren MP4/5B from his title-winning 1990 campaign. GETTY IMAGES

